

Japan: Kyushu Volcanoes, Onsen & Golf

Ten days around Japan's southern island: the Yamanami Highway and the Aso caldera, Takachiho Gorge, the Nichinan coast, Sakurajima, Ibusuki, the Kirishima volcanoes and Unzen, with nights in onsen ryokans and golf at Phoenix Country Club and Ibusuki.

10 days: 8 riding, 2 golf · **Riding:** about 1,300 km (810 mi) · **Start and finish:** Fukuoka · **Best:** mid-October to late November · **Drive on the left**

Arrive Fukuoka

Fly into Fukuoka and collect the bikes. Evening at the yatai food stalls along the river in Nakasu.

Overnight: Fukuoka

Day 1 Fukuoka to Kurokawa Onsen

About 160 km (100 mi)

East through Hita, the old merchant town, to the Kokonoe “Yume” suspension bridge, then the Yamanami Highway across the Kuju highlands. The night in Kurokawa Onsen, a riverside village of wooden inns where you buy one pass and walk between outdoor baths.

By way of: Hita · Kokonoe Yume Otsurihashi · Yamanami Highway · Kuju highlands

Overnight: Kurokawa Onsen (ryokan)

Day 2 Kurokawa to Takachiho

About 150 km (95 mi)

Into the Aso caldera, one of the largest in the world: the Milk Road along the rim, the Daikanbo lookout, the Aso Panorama Line past Kusasenri's grass plain and the active Nakadake crater (when open). South-east through the hills to Takachiho Gorge.

By way of: Milk Road · Daikanbo · Aso Panorama Line · Kusasenri · Takamori

Overnight: Takachiho

Day 3 Takachiho to Miyazaki

About 150 km (95 mi)

Row a boat under the Manai Falls in the gorge in the morning, then down the valley to the Pacific at Hyuga and south along the coast to Miyazaki and the Seagaia resort.

By way of: Takachiho Gorge · Hinokage · Hyuga · Cape Hyuga

Overnight: Miyazaki (Seagaia)

Day 4 Golf at Phoenix Country Club

A round at Phoenix Country Club, a pine-lined seaside course and home of the Dunlop Phoenix tournament. Caddies are compulsory; book through the club's English tee-time service.

Overnight: Miyazaki (Seagaia)

Day 5 Miyazaki to Kagoshima

About 200 km (125 mi)

The Nichinan coast road south past Aoshima's "devil's washboard" rocks and Udo Shrine in its sea cave, then across the Osumi peninsula to Sakurajima, the smoking volcano in Kagoshima Bay. Ride the lava-field roads, then take the 15-minute ferry across to Kagoshima.

By way of: Aoshima · Nichinan coast · Udo Shrine · Kanoya · Sakurajima · Sakurajima ferry

Overnight: Kagoshima

Day 6 Kagoshima to Ibusuki, golf

About 60 km (40 mi)

A short ride down the bay to Ibusuki and an afternoon round at Ibusuki Golf Club, with Mount Kaimon, the "Satsuma Fuji", over the fairways. End the day buried in the hot sand baths on the beach.

By way of: Kiire · Ibusuki

Overnight: Ibusuki

Day 7 Ibusuki to Kirishima

About 150 km (95 mi)

Past Lake Ikeda and Mount Kaimon to Chiran's samurai gardens, then north to the Kirishima volcano range: the Kirishima Skyline and Ebino Kogen plateau, ending at a Kirishima onsen.

By way of: Lake Ikeda · Chiran · Kirishima Skyline · Ebino Kogen

Overnight: Kirishima Onsen (ryokan)

Day 8 Kirishima to Kumamoto

About 150 km (95 mi)

Through the Kuma river valley at Hitoyoshi, famous for its rice shochu, then north to Kumamoto and its restored castle.

By way of: Ebino · Hitoyoshi · Kuma River · Yatsushiro

Overnight: Kumamoto

Day 9 Kumamoto to Unzen

About 120 km (75 mi) plus ferry

The car ferry from Kumamoto Port across the Ariake Sea to Shimabara (about an hour), then up into Unzen, a mountain onsen town of steaming "hells" below Mount Fugen.

By way of: Kumamoto Port · Ariake Sea ferry · Shimabara · Nita Pass

Overnight: Unzen Onsen (ryokan)

Day 10 Unzen to Fukuoka

About 160 km (100 mi)

Down the Shimabara peninsula and up the Ariake coast, with a stop at Ureshino's hot springs and tea fields, then back to Fukuoka.

By way of: Obama Onsen · Isahaya · Ureshino · Takeo · Saga

Overnight: Fukuoka

Depart Fly home from Fukuoka

Return the bikes and fly home.

Best time to go

- Best: mid-October to late November. Dry, cool riding weather and autumn colour in the Kuju highlands and Aso, peaking late October to mid-November.
 - Good: late March to mid-May. Spring green on the Aso grasslands; avoid Golden Week (late April to early May), when roads and inns are full.
 - Avoid: June to mid-July (rainy season) and August to September (heat and typhoons).
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Motorcycle rental in Fukuoka

- EagleRider Fukuoka: BMW R 1250 GS and other BMWs (eaglerider.com)
 - Rental819: Japan's largest rental chain, with shops in Fukuoka including near the airport, mostly Japanese bikes (rental819.com)
 - rentalmotorbike.com: English booking, three-day minimum
 - You need an International Driving Permit under the 1949 Geneva Convention (from AAA in the US), plus your home licence and passport.
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Golf

- Phoenix Country Club, Miyazaki: visitors welcome, caddies compulsory
 - Ibusuki Golf Club, Kagoshima: views of Mount Kaimon
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Riding notes

- Mountain roads close for volcanic activity at times; check the Aso and Sakurajima advisories the day before.
- Book onsen ryokans early: dinner is usually served at a set time, so plan to arrive by 4 to 5 pm.
- Expressway tolls are paid at the booth or with an ETC card fitted to the rental bike.

Draft route. Distances and times are approximate; check road, pass and ferry conditions before each day.